

What I never saw

“Hollow Notes” usually closed at around 10 in the night, after all the people managed to drink their sorrows away. Evelyn was a regular she’d come at around 7 after her art classes for blind kids. She taught Art at the community centre to the blind kids down at Harvey street. This evening wasn’t so different from the others. Edith dropped off Evelyn at the bar, Evelyn was a bit late today because one of children’s parents decided to throw a surprise party for Evelyn for all her faithful years of service to the blind community. It was 8:30 today when she arrived today.

As she took out her own walking stick she began to reach for the door, she always felt the cold steel handle to the door, she opened it and started to feel her way to the bar, as she swaying around her walking stick trying to feel obstructions in her path, her walking stick suddenly hit an object in her path, “I’m sorry, did I hit you?”, “Not at all, please would you like me to help you walk to the bar”, “You are too kind, but I’ll manage like I always have, Thank you”. Evelyn and the man began walking their own ways, their backs turned to each other.

“Hollow notes” was a jazz bar neatly tucked away in the middle of Harvey street, the bar originally never served drinks but was only a centre for the black folks to enjoy jazz. The bar didn’t look like much from the outside, just a wooden sign hung by loose links, the letters faded and beginning to chip away, like the voice of a singer who’s beginning to forget the words. The windows outside were fogged and bore a slight yellow patina around the corners like a photograph left outside in the sun for too long.

But inside—

Was another story

The moment you step in, the door gives off a low creak, and the sound folds behind you like velvet being drawn shut. Warm amber light spills from antique sconces and table lamps, glowing soft through colored glass shades. The walls are dark mahogany, wrapped in peeling jazz posters, framed black-and-white photographs of musicians long gone, and newspaper clippings curled at the corners. The scent is unmistakable: a mix of aged whiskey, old wood, leather, and a distant note of orange peel and dust.

In the far corner, a crackling vinyl record spins on a vintage turntable behind the bar, always something smooth like Miles Davis, Chet Baker, maybe a woman’s voice dripping like smoke over piano keys. The speakers aren’t perfect there’s a faint hiss but somehow it makes the sound feel more real. More lived-in.

The bar itself is carved oak, timeworn and full of nicks like it’s listened to a thousand secrets. A single glass of bourbon left sitting too long makes a perfect ring like a timestamp in the past. Behind the bar, rows of half-full bottles stand like memory keepers, their labels aged and peeling.

Today was special instead of the routine of jazz being played over an old vinyl record players, Martin and Cassie Dechané, the town favorites would be performing live today at the Hollow notes, now Evelyn could not possibly pass up this opportunity to meet and listen to the Dechané’s, so she made sure to be on time today.

“Missed you yesterday Eve, glad to see you today”, “Thanks Mayor, how could I miss this day, I’ve always wanted to see them”, Evelyn made herself comfortable at the bar, she always sat at the corner turn opposite to the sound of the jazz player, “Just the usual, Scott”, “I’m sorry ma’am Scott isn’t here today, I’m Rose, I’ll be your bartender for the night, what can I serve you today?”, “Oh no

wonder I didn't Scott mumbling behind the bar like he always is haha... I'll have a Daiquiri, Rose, equal parts white and lime juice, with just a hint of sugar syrup and oh...a chilled glass please", "lovely choice ma'am, I'll get started on your drink and what about you sir, what would you like today?", "I'll have the double bourbon. Neat. No ice. No chaser, I say let it burn today", Rose nodded slightly with a content smile and got to getting the drinks ready right away.

"Let it burn huh", "Yeah", "You were here yesterday", Evelyn smiled slightly, "I recognize your voice, thank you for your offer yesterday", "No-No it was the least I could do then"... "You have a beautiful smile...", "I appreciate the flattery, even for the elderly, now I wish I could say the same about yours, but unfortunately I can't see your smile, matter fact I can't see anything at all", the man nodded but didn't say anything, "sorry where are my manners, I'm Evelyn", "...Ray", "pleased to meet you Ray", "likewise".

"Here you go, bourbon for the gentleman and the daiquiri for the lady", "quick with your hands Rose", Evelyn said with a smirk on her face, "...the best I can do ma'am, enjoy your evening". "So Ray what brings you here today", Evelyn took a sip her drink while waiting for Ray to answer, "Damn Rose you weren't messing around, this is actually great", "ah you know it's uh...some old unfinished business, and...it's about time I sorted some things out you know"... "how about you Evelyn you come here often?, I mean you were gonna order a "usual", so I assume yes", "Yeah you can say that, I just like to come here after work, not to drink God no haha, but the Jazz, I love it and I'm here to listen to Martin and Cassie today, they're just...great, you know them?" "I'd love to", "so you're not from around here then, are you Ray?", "that'd be correct", "so where are you from Ray, if you don't mind me asking", Ray finally took a sip of his bourbon, it burned like hell, you could see the regret on his face for not ordering a chaser, "well Evelyn, I ... I-I haven't been home for a while you see, I've just been running from things", Ray took a deep breath preparing himself for the second sip, "Evelyn, you see I...uh have been longing for something my whole life, something I knew I was never worthy of", Evelyn set her drink on the bar after another sip, "and what would that be, Ray...?", "A second chance, a chance at redemption", Rose noticed that the man's hands were practically shaking at this point, "are you ok, sir?", "yeah I'm fine its just that I haven't had anything to drink for a while, this is my first time in years", "any particular reasons for breaking your promise of sobriety, Ray?"

Ray looked at Evelyn for a while noticing her ash green eyes, "did I already say you have the most beautiful eyes I have ever seen, Evelyn?", "oh stop that" Evelyn added jokingly, "Evelyn... you do have the most beautiful eyes I have ever seen...", the silence built up intensely, like poison had filled the air between them unable to say anything.

Their momentary silence was broken by slow piano keys, Martin started his signature and Cassie soon followed behind with the sax, "Oh what a pleasant surprise, I was wondering when these two would start playing, my God", Evelyn immediately turned behind to listen to the Dechanés, Ray looking to drown himself in alcohol, finished the remaining of his drink in one shot, and gently put down the glass on the bar, Evelyn noticed the glass clinking against the table, turned back to Ray again, "oh you're done already, we just got started it's a special night, Martin just started his best pieces its called "Our memories of time", you have to this song a chance ray, after a few moments of content filled silence Ray finally asked for another glass of bourbon, "there we go ray", Evelyn said laughingly.

Ray soon noticed Evelyn tapping her fingers on the bar to the ever slow and melancholic tune of "our memories of time", "I can still hear him sometimes between the notes when I come here", Ray tried to listen to the song but he never could take his mind off of Evelyn's words after that.

The Dechanés had just finished their second set. The bar had grown quieter, not emptier—just softer, more golden. Evelyn’s second daiquiri was half-melted in her glass. She traced her fingers along the condensation ring, slow and aimless.

She sighed, not knowing why she was about to speak.

Maybe it was the music.

Maybe it was the bourbon voice of Ray beside her.

Or maybe it was time.

“It’s funny... You ever carry someone in your bones for so long that you forget they’re not supposed to be there anymore?”

She let the question hang, not expecting an answer.

“My husband. Colt. He was—well, he is—a man I thought I’d spend forever with. You know the type. Quiet. Stubborn. Had a way of loving that felt like holding your breath.”

Ray didn’t say anything. She kept going. “Seventeen years, 4 months, 16 days..., we crashed. Not just the car... us. He was drinking. I lost my eyes. He lost his... everything else, I think.”

She took a sip, tilted her face toward the ceiling like she could still see stars.

“People say I should hate him. Hell, I thought I did for a while. But grief’s a trickster—it rots the pain so deep you mistake it for hatred. But underneath... it wasn’t hate.” “It was love. Still is, in a pathetic way. But love doesn’t mean you hold on. Sometimes it means you let them go and hope they find whatever corner of themselves they left behind.”

Ray’s fingers clenched around his glass, the bourbon long gone. His throat burned more now from her words than the whiskey.

Ray (quietly):

“And you forgave him?”

“Long before the bruises faded. I forgave him the night I realized he’d never forgive himself.”

She chuckled—soft, bitter.

“Men always think forgiveness is a gift they have to deserve. Like love. Like tenderness. But it’s not about them. It’s about me. I didn’t want to die hating someone I once whispered my forever to.”

Ray looked at her, the glow of the barlight casting shadows beneath his eyes like ghosts leaning in.

“You talk like it’s easy. Like all wounds scab the same. But some people... some of us shouldn’t be forgiven.”

Evelyn turned her head slightly, curious now.

“And who decides that? You?”

Ray (sternly):

“Yes. Because I know what I did. Because some things burn too deep to ever wash clean. There are actions that stain you, Evelyn. Regret that sets in your marrow. And no matter how soft the voice that says ‘I forgive you,’ it doesn’t unmake the truth.”

Evelyn:

“Then what? You punish yourself forever?”

Ray:

“Maybe. Maybe that’s the cost of knowing you broke someone.”

She was quiet for a moment. The jazz returned like a tide—slow brushes of snare and soft horn sighs.

Evelyn (gently):

“Forgiveness doesn’t undo pain, Ray. It doesn’t erase what happened. It just... gives it somewhere to rest. Otherwise, we carry it. Bleeding, infected. It poisons everything.”

Ray:

“But what if I deserve to be poisoned?”

Evelyn:

“Then you’ll die with a full bottle and an empty soul.”

She reached for her glass but didn’t drink.

“You said something earlier... about longing. About not being worthy of a second chance.”

Ray:

“I’m not.”

Evelyn:

“And yet, you’re here.”

A pause. Long. Heavy.

“You know what I miss most about him?”

Ray dared to look at her, his eyes swimming with the beginning of tears.

“His silence,” she said. “That quiet between the chaos. He never said sorry. Not once. But I think if he ever did... I’d crumble.”

Ray stood. Barely.

Ray:

“Then maybe it’s better he didn’t.”

He walked away from the bar, stumbling slightly. Evelyn didn't stop him.

She sat there for a while. Listening to the music. Her fingers curled around the edge of the glass as if it held the weight of seventeen years.

Rose came by to clear the table. "He left something for you, Miss Evelyn."

She handed her a small folded piece of thick paper.

Braille. It read:

Evelyn,

My name isn't Ray.

It's Colt.

I ran.

Seventeen years, 4 months, 16 days

Not from you

from the weight of what I did.

From the wreckage I made of your life.

I thought silence would hurt less than my face ever could.

I came back, not for your forgiveness

I knew, somehow, that you had already given it.

I came back to hear you speak.

To sit in the warmth of your voice.

I could never forgive myself, Evelyn.

You were my home,

and I spent seventeen years wandering outside the door.

Thank you

for being kind to a stranger

who wasn't one.

This is goodbye.

Not from guilt

but from peace.

—Colt

Evelyn after reading it fully let out a small painful laugh.

“You ran away again, Colt, but we’ll meet in another life...hopefully”